

4.5 Assessment criteria for performance from a score

Holistic assessment criterion

Holistic (AO1)		
36–40	Outstanding	Impressive and imaginative: the student has stamped their personal musical authority on the performance. Complete (or almost complete) control of technique, style and interpretation. Sense of musical wholeness with no passage sub-standard.
31–35	Excellent	Convincing throughout: and an engaging performance. Secure technique and sensitivity of style and interpretation. Any errors and/or misjudgements are marginal.
26–30	Confident	Convincing for most of the time in technique, style and interpretation. Secure technique and sensitive interpretation. Some errors and/or misjudgements, but too few to have a big impact.
21–25	Competent	Generally secure and conscientious in technique and interpretation. Some errors and/or misjudgements, but the piece still has some direction and flow.
16–20	Adequate	A serious attempt but probably a performance with limited maturity and assurance. Some control of technique and interpretation. Errors, misjudgements and technical problems begin to be obtrusive, but the performance still broadly holds together.
11–15	Basic	Positive features are fairly few with the performance inconsistent and/or immature. Basic technical control, fluency and accuracy and a basic understanding of interpretative issues. Errors, misjudgements and technical problems are obtrusive.
6–10	Limited	Positive features are few. A few encouraging signs, but considerable difficulties with a weak performance in most areas. Perhaps under the required length.
1–5	Poor	Positive features are very few indeed, being heavily outweighed by errors, misjudgements and technical problems. In practice, a mark in the 1–5 band is appropriate only for work which is seriously under the required performance length and/or difficulty or too incomplete to be marked using the five detailed assessment criteria.
0	No positive features can be clearly identified.	

Detailed assessment criteria

Teacher and moderators apply **all five** of the following assessment criteria where a score exists.

Criterion 1: Quality of outcome

Overall security and effectiveness of the performance.
Interpretation and musical communication. Extent to which the piece meets the specification in terms of duration.

The text in *italics* refers to ensemble performances only.

Criterion 1: Quality of outcome (AO1)		
8	Outstanding	Mature, exciting and imaginative interpretation with a strong sense of authority and musical communication. <i>Consistently responsive reaction to other parts and if necessary adjustment to them. Thorough awareness of balance.</i>
7	Excellent	Sensitive interpretation, with a good sense of style and musical communication. <i>Excellent reaction to other parts and if necessary adjustment to them. Good awareness of balance throughout.</i>
6	Confident	Confident (if not always subtle) interpretation but consistent and with fairly good musical communication. <i>Generally good reaction to other parts and if necessary adjustment to them. Good awareness of balance throughout.</i>
5	Competent	Broadly satisfying interpretation with a few weaknesses not seriously detracting from the overall impression, but with limited success in musical communication. <i>Generally reasonably good reaction to other parts and some ability to adjust to them if necessary, but also a few difficulties. Some awareness of balance throughout.</i>
4	Adequate	Serious attempt at interpretation, but some obvious technical weaknesses and/or inconsistency, or very mechanical. <i>Some ability to react to other parts and adjust to them if necessary, but with clear difficulties. At least some awareness of balance throughout.</i>
3	Basic	Reasonable attempt (eg in isolated expressive passages), but marred by technical problems or brevity. <i>Some basic ability to react to other parts, but with clear difficulties, and probably little ability to adjust. At least some awareness of balance throughout.</i>
2	Limited	Limited sense of assurance and seriously compromised by lack of sophistication accuracy and/or brevity. <i>Limited ability to react to other parts. There are numerous difficulties, and probably little or no ability to adjust. Limited awareness of balance.</i>
1	Poor	Very little evidence of competence. Seriously under-length. <i>There are numerous difficulties and very little evidence of reaction to other parts. Little or no awareness of balance.</i>

Criterion 2: Pitch and rhythm

Accuracy of pitch. Accuracy of rhythm. NB: Intonation is **not** considered here, but under Criterion 4.

Criterion 2: Pitch and rhythm (AO1)		
8	Outstanding	Wholly accurate, or with only one or two tiny errors.
7	Excellent	Mostly accurate: with just one or two small but noticeable errors.
6	Confident	Generally accurate: with a few small errors.
5	Competent	Mainly accurate, despite some obtrusive errors.
4	Adequate	Broadly accurate for the majority of the piece, despite fairly numerous obtrusive errors (for example, concentrated in the more difficult passages).
3	Basic	Accurate from time to time, for example only in the most straightforward passages
2	Limited	Pitches and/or rhythms are only accurate for a few bars at a time.
1	Poor	Pitches and/or rhythms are only accurate for a few beats at a time.
0	No positive features can be clearly identified.	

**Criterion 3:
Fluency and tempo**

Maintenance of continuity (fluency). Tempo (including any necessary sectional tempo changes, ritenutos, and rubato) in accordance with the composer's direction(s) and/or the stylistic demands of the piece.

Criterion 3: Fluency and tempo (AO1)		
8	Outstanding	Fluent and completely assured throughout — entirely free of hesitation. Tempo entirely appropriate throughout.
7	Excellent	Fluent — entirely or virtually free of hesitation. Tempo appropriate but perhaps one or two minor misjudgements (eg an overdone or missed rit.).
6	Confident	Fluent with no significant hesitation. Main tempo appropriate but perhaps one or two noticeably misjudged moments.
5	Competent	Reasonably fluent, despite the occasional slight hesitation. Main tempo may be slightly too fast or too slow. Perhaps errors, omissions or a lack of subtlety elsewhere.
4	Adequate	Fluent for the majority of the piece, although some errors are sufficient to interrupt the flow. Main tempo may be too fast or too slow. Mechanical: errors, omissions, and a lack of subtlety elsewhere.
3	Basic	Fluency is repeatedly compromised. Main tempo considerably too fast or too slow. Very mechanical: with noticeable errors and omissions.
2	Limited	Extremely halting performance, with frequent stops and hesitations.
1	Poor	Incoherent performance, with no sense of musical flow.
0	No positive features can be clearly identified.	

Criterion 4: Tone and technique

Quality of instrumental or vocal sound ('tone quality'). Intonation and other aspects of instrumental or vocal technique (bowing, pedalling, etc as appropriate).

Criterion 4: Tone and technique (AO1)		
8	Outstanding	Impressive tone quality throughout the pitch range. Thorough technical control. Intonation completely secure.
7	Excellent	Good tone quality throughout the pitch range. Very good technical control. Intonation secure, despite one or two slightly out-of-tune notes.
6	Confident	Good tone quality throughout the pitch range, except at the extremities or at moments of technical difficulty. Generally good technical control. Intonation secure, despite a few slightly out-of-tune notes.
5	Competent	Good tone quality across most of the pitch range. Fairly good technical control, but occasional technical weaknesses. Intonation reasonably secure, despite some noticeably out-of-tune notes.
4	Adequate	Generally acceptable tone quality, although occasionally dull. Some technical control, but problems begin to be obtrusive. Intonation sometimes secure, but several patches are weak.
3	Basic	Tone quality acceptable at times but often dull, thin or coarse. Technical control still evident at times, but there are significant problems. Intonation rarely secure or consistently sharp/flat.
2	Limited	Tone quality acceptable occasionally, but mostly dull, thin or coarse. Technical control only intermittent. Intonation scarcely ever secure and likely to be very inconsistent.
1	Poor	Very little control of tone or technique. Intonation severely deficient virtually throughout.
0	No positive features can be clearly identified.	

**Criterion 5:
Phrasing,
articulation and
dynamics**

Observance of performance directions for phrasing, articulation and dynamics and the subtlety of their realisation where the composer has indicated them. Appropriate and subtle use of phrasing, articulation and dynamics where an Urtext edition is used. Dynamic range need not always be great (eg on a recorder).

Criterion 5: Phrasing, articulation and dynamics (AO1)		
8	Outstanding	Subtle phrasing and articulation throughout. Dynamics appropriate and imaginative throughout.
7	Excellent	Phrasing and articulation appropriate throughout. Dynamics are convincing and effective, although very occasionally missing, under- or over-played.
6	Confident	Some careful attention to phrasing and articulation. Dynamics are generally effective, although occasionally missing, under- or over-played.
5	Competent	Phrasing is reasonably well shaped and there is some attention to articulation. Some effective use of dynamics, but a few opportunities are missed or mishandled.
4	Adequate	Some attempt at phrasing and articulation, but needs more control. Some reasonable use of dynamics, but lacking real interest.
3	Basic	Basic attempt to shape the music through phrasing and articulation, but little contrast is achieved nor is the legato secure. Some use of dynamics, but some errors and misjudgements as well as omissions.
2	Limited	Limited attempt to shape the music through phrasing and/or articulation. Little use of dynamics, probably with errors and misjudgements as well as omissions.
1	Poor	Scarcely any (or no) phrasing and articulation. Very few or no dynamics.
0	No positive features can be clearly identified.	

Criterion 6:
The performance
as a whole

Overall musical impression. Structure and planning of programme.

Criterion 6: The performance as a whole (AO1)		
10	Outstanding	Very impressive musically. A striking performance throughout. Highly imaginative choice of programme. Pieces in an entirely suitable order. Planning shows great care and thoroughness.
9	Excellent	Very good musically. Imaginative choice of programme. Pieces in an entirely suitable order. Planning shows care and thoroughness.
8	Confident	Good musically, apart from a few minor lapses. Well-considered choice of programme. Pieces in a suitable order. Planning careful and generally effective.
7	Competent	Good musically, apart from a few lapses. Generally well-considered choice of pieces. Pieces in a generally suitable order. Planning generally careful and mostly effective.
6	Adequate	Secure musically and broadly successful, but short of musical interest. Some care in choosing the programme, but there may be some lack of contrast or coherence. Order of pieces is a little illogical. Planning shows some care.
5	Basic	Solid musically and broadly successful, but lacking in real musical interest. Some care in choosing the programme, but lack of real contrast and/or coherence. Order of pieces fails to convince. Some basic planning has taken place.
3-4	Limited	Limited musical interest, perhaps because the performance is under-length. Limited thought given to choosing the programme, with lack of contrast and/or little coherence. Pieces in more or less random order. Little evidence of careful planning.
1-2	Poor	A performance with very few musical merits, partly because it is under-length. More or less random collection of pieces. Very little evidence of planning.
0	No positive features can be clearly identified.	